

“Development and environment are not adversaries”

Uttarakhand Chief Minister Pushkar Singh Dhami on industrial expansion, investor confidence, jobs, reverse migration and aspirations of the new generation

BY SIDDHARTH ZARABI

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Long associated with pilgrimage, tourism and the Himalayas, Uttarakhand is building a broader economic identity. *Business Today* research places it at the forefront of manufacturing growth among India's 11 hill states, with Gross State Value Addition rising 143% over the past decade.

Chief Minister Pushkar Singh Dhami, 50, is leading the next phase of development as the state seeks to expand beyond its traditional strengths and emerge as a destination for investment, innovation and enterprise. A

law graduate with a postgraduate degree in human resource management and industrial relations, Dhami represents Champawat in the Uttarakhand Legislative Assembly. Now in his second tenure as Chief Minister, he oversees key portfolios, including home, finance, planning, industry and personnel, bringing together legislative experience and executive responsibility at a crucial moment in the state's economic journey. Edited excerpts.

Q: *BT's* research shows Uttarakhand recorded the fastest manufacturing growth among 11 hill states. Has the state changed?

A: Uttarakhand has changed greatly. In 2023, we held a Global Investors Summit under the guidance of Prime Minister Narendra Modi. People from more than 50 countries participated. MoUs (memorandum of understanding) were signed, and investments worth lakhs of crores of rupees has come. There is a perception that investor summits see MoUs but without implementation on the ground. In our case, there was significant implementation. We prepared in advance to make policies that attract investors and made it easier for them to set up industries. We simplified wherever needed.

Our connectivity is good. The state is close to the